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Official Records

President: Mr. Kőrösi (Hungary)

The meeting was called to order at 10.05 p.m.

High-level meeting on the midterm review of the Sendai Framework

Agenda item 18 (continued)

(c) Disaster risk reduction

Draft resolution (A/77/L.70)

The President: The General Assembly will now resume its consideration of sub-item (c) of agenda item 18, entitled “Disaster risk reduction”, to hold the high-level meeting of the General Assembly on the midterm review of the Sendai Framework, in accordance with resolution 76/204 of 17 December 2021. This high-level meeting will focus on the theme: “Working together to reduce risk for a resilient future”.

In connection with the item, the General Assembly has before it a draft resolution issued as document A/77/L.70.

It is a pleasure to welcome representatives to this high-level meeting. Let me extend special thanks to the two representatives who have joined us here. One of them, Mr. Mustafa Kemal Kılıç, came from the earthquake zone in Türkiye to be with us today. I am sure we have much to learn from his first-hand insights on how to identify risks, assess the gaps and bolster resilience in the future.

As the earthquake across Türkiye and Syria and the recent Cyclone Mocha in Myanmar and Bangladesh made clear, disasters know no borders. They are also

connected to each other and to us through our actions and inaction.

To better manage disaster risks, we must understand why and how disasters are connected and address our role in perpetuating them. That has become an inevitable priority for all countries, regardless of geography. But then, to quote Robert Louis Stevenson, “The mark of a good action is that it appears inevitable in retrospect.”

The Sendai Framework was the first of the landmark international agreements adopted in 2015. In many ways, it was a framework ahead of its time. Member States called for a critical shift towards the proactive management of risks before the onset of disaster. World leaders pledged to pursue risk-informed decision-making, build resilience, tackle the impacts of climate change and create pathways for sustainable development.

Eight years on, we must admit that our progress has not kept pace with the urgency of our days. The known number of people affected by disasters has jumped eightyfold since 2015. The shocks ignited by unattended risk — and amplified by the coronavirus disease, conflict and climate change — have torn through our systems across the world. They have left millions homeless and starving. They upended supply chains. They laid bare the gross inequities of an international financial order that has often prized profits over people. How did we get here?

We must acknowledge that our decisions on how we consume, produce, fuel, finance and plan are still out of sync with the reality that nature’s resources are

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finite. We have to rethink and recalibrate our systems, our structures. We should acknowledge our enormous responsibility for human-induced climate change. And we have to stop undervaluing the environmental and other costs of our actions. As accountants like to say, it is not a calculated risk, if one has not calculated it.

This midterm review is our last chance before 2030 to collectively change course. Starting today, let us ensure our choices are planet-smart and people-centred. Let us measure prosperity with a tool that widens the lens of the gross domestic product — one that captures the true cost of human, social, natural and built capital, meaning the total assets of a nation. By moving beyond gross domestic product, we can shift away from extractive and transactional behaviours, moving towards modes of inclusion and solidarity.

In those efforts, let us ensure that risk governance and management evolve in ways that are proportionate to the challenges at hand. The more we improve scientific capabilities and manage residual risks, the better our societies will withstand the shocks.

I challenge Member States to account for risk in every decision that impacts how we live, consume, build and invest; to shift the temporal frame from short-term decision-making to one that also includes long-term perspectives; to make the sustainable transformations in global and local risk governance; to value resilience in the global financial systems by redressing how disaster risk is treated; to increase and incentivize investments in prevention and rapid response; and, above all, to place people at the centre of prevention efforts.

By engaging those most affected by disasters, we can reverse the trends towards inequality, restricted civic space and rising vulnerability, in short: anticipate risks, calculate, factor in, prepare, prevent, respond rapidly and build the lessons learned into the next action plans. Those issues are at the core of the political declaration that will be adopted today. And they are embodied in the Charter of the United Nations we have pledged to uphold. I urge Member States to renew the drive for a multilateral system ready for a new risk landscape. The transformation towards resilience is ours to craft.

In accordance with rule 70 of the rules of procedure of the General Assembly, I now give the floor to the Deputy Secretary-General, Her Excellency Ms. Amina Mohammed.

The Deputy Secretary-General: I am delighted to join His Excellency Mr. Csaba Kőrösi in welcoming representatives to the United Nations as we gather to take stock of our progress towards implementing the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction.

Our world is at a defining point in history. As we review our journey halfway to 2030, we must acknowledge that progress has been weak and insufficient. Sadly, as a result of not meeting our climate and broader Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) commitments, natural disasters that could have been prevented have claimed hundreds of thousands of lives and forced the involuntary displacement of millions of people — mainly women, children and other vulnerable groups.

Exacerbating that challenge, we faced the coronavirus disease pandemic; the triple crisis of climate change, biodiversity loss and pollution; rising costs of living and skyrocketing inequality. All of that has been further exacerbated by the effects of the war in Ukraine.

Meanwhile, structural governance omissions within the banking and global financial systems demonstrate the fragility of economic and financial stability in the face of systemic risks and shocks.

And on climate, scientists warn that we are headed to cascading and irreversible impacts of global warming, including extreme weather events exposing humans and other species to life-threatening climatic conditions. Record-breaking heatwaves have hit the Iberian Peninsula and North African countries with temperatures of 106°F just last week and 113°F in South-East Asia, with extended droughts wrecking harvests and aggravating human health in those regions. Floods and landslides in Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of the Congo have left more than 9,000 people homeless and 5,500 people missing and are costing those Governments more than \$100 billion in infrastructure rehabilitation.

Addressing those challenges means changing our response to risk through systemic thinking, collaborative action and the smart, agile deployment of responses to prevent, manage and mitigate global risks.

Disaster risk reduction is critical. Nothing erodes sustainable development like disasters, which can often destroy decades of progress in minutes. The failure to identify, prevent and reduce risks before they

manifest as disasters not only places the Sustainable Development Goals in jeopardy, but it also affects the most vulnerable people in the world first and worst.

Addressing that challenge requires integrated, cross-sectoral action across the entire 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and scaled-up measures at the local, national and regional levels. We must build the resilience of communities, countries and natural ecosystems alike in a holistic way. Understanding and managing disaster risk and tackling root causes and drivers of exposure as part of integrated risk-informed approaches are all indispensable.

In the midterm review of the Sendai Framework, Member States and stakeholders identify where and how we must collectively change our relationship to risk and integrate current and future risks into all of our decisions, actions and choices.

Together, we need to upgrade our governance and financial systems to ensure accountability for managing risks and deploy resources to protect people and natural capital. We also need to address market “short-termism” and other failures using fiscal and market-based measures for greater systemic resilience. Decisions should always be based on science, strategic foresight and fully integrating local, traditional and indigenous knowledge. Science would also need to inform and anticipate emerging environmental and biological risks and any emerging technological hazards.

As we look to the 2023 SDG summit and the summit of the future, it is time to make a dramatic shift — from managing disasters to managing risk and investing in prevention. People are depending on it. Communities and countries are depending on it. Sustainable development in itself is depending on us delivering. And the future of our planet is depending on it.

So, we will need to work together — Member States, investors, businesses, civil society and the entire United Nations system — to ensure that the calls contained in the midterm review are woven across all our agendas, frameworks, conventions and investments.

Managing risk today is not an option. It is a global imperative, a commitment, and it belongs to each and every one of us. Let us endeavour to make that a reality as we meet in September to take stock of both the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and the Paris Agreement on Climate Change.

The President: I thank the Deputy Secretary-General for her statement.

Before proceeding further, and as indicated in my letter dated 11 May 2023, I would like to consult Members on inviting the following speakers to make statements: Ms. Mami Mizutori, Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Disaster Risk Reduction; Ms. Mwanahamisi Singano, Senior Global Policy Lead at the Women’s Environment and Development Organization; and Mr. Mustafa Kemal Kilinç, youth representative from the earthquake zone in Türkiye.

If there is no objection, may I take it that it is the wish of the General Assembly, without setting a precedent, to invite these speakers to make statements at this meeting?

It was so decided (decision 77/558).

The President: I now give the floor to Ms. Mizutori.

Ms. Mizutori: It is a pleasure to be a part of this global gathering for the midterm review of the Sendai Framework, a process mandated by the General Assembly that began in October 2021. It has seen unprecedented commitment by Member States and stakeholders. I take this as an indicator of the importance accorded to understanding and managing risk by States and non-State actors pursuing the goal of the Sendai Framework and risk-informed sustainable development.

The spirit of 2015, which characterized the adoption of the Sendai Framework and other landmark agreements, is now buzzing through the parliament of humankind here in the General Assembly, together with a renewed sense of urgency. And I am delighted to see many of the representatives of countries, civil society and United Nations organizations in this Hall. We acknowledge the wisdom and boldness of the leaders who gathered in Sendai in March 2015 to enable the historic global commitment to reduce disaster risk and build resilience. I commend all Member States that have overseen its implementation to date and sincerely thank them for their tireless efforts towards a resilient and sustainable future.

I would also like to recognize the critical role in implementation played by civil society, women’s and youth organizations, the scientific and academic communities, not to mention businesses, professional associations and private sector financial institutions, among many others. Their efforts truly embody

the guiding principle of all-of-society engagement and partnership.

Despite enormous challenges to implementation, thanks to the collective efforts of Member States and stakeholders, the midterm review shows that there has been progress in realizing the outcomes, goals and targets of the Sendai Framework.

Governments and stakeholders are better able to understand risks, as well as their cascading impacts; and justice, social cohesion and human rights are more prominently represented. With improved understanding, they are better placed to bring the transformations required to prevent, reduce or manage those risks. That has been aided by a growing number of countries establishing or upgrading national loss accounting systems, by improvements in availability and the application of risk data and information, and by more widespread use of the Sendai Framework monitor.

There has been a significant increase in the number of countries with national strategies for disaster risk reduction, and growth in regional and subregional cooperation mechanisms. That is however not the case at the local level.

While inadequate pricing of disaster risks in public and private investment decisions and a lack of adequate financing remain major roadblocks, there have been innovations in risk financing and risk transfer mechanisms — from adaptive social protection to insurance to disaster debt moratoriums and catastrophe bonds.

Further integration of risk reduction in official development assistance is observed, although it remains focused on reactive measures.

There has been increased focus and improvement in multilateral cooperation across regions, leading to enhanced preparedness and effectiveness of responses. Equally, understanding risk in protracted crises and multi-hazard early-warning systems have improved even if overall access remains inadequate. I have seen first-hand in Madagascar, Barbados and India, among other places, how breaking down institutional silos is helping Governments optimize investments and build resilience.

However, progress remains unequal across geographies, skills and income levels. When risks manifest as disasters, they continue to disproportionately affect least developed countries, small island

developing States, landlocked developing countries, African countries and middle-income countries. As risks are left unattended, disasters are materializing faster, surpassing our ability to cope with increasingly dire consequences for people, livelihoods, societies and the ecosystems on which we depend.

The imperative to realize the outcome, goal and targets of the Sendai Framework is more important today than ever before. As we look to accelerate risk-informed action to 2030 and a resilient future, I urge all States and stakeholders to take forward the calls to action to be adopted in the political declaration today (A/77/L.70). Key among these are strengthening the availability of and capacity to apply risk information and improved mechanisms for sharing among sectors, ministries, organizations and borders; strengthening multi-hazard risk governance with responsibility for risk reduction assumed by all State institutions, supported by adequate legal and regulatory frameworks and resources, with all-of-society engagement and partnership; ensuring that financial authorities integrate disaster risk reduction into their work to incentivize and scale up public and private domestic and international investment, and collaborate with financial and capital market institutions to better integrate disaster risk in their decisions; improving the means of implementation and strengthening capacity-building, financial resources, data and technology and partnerships; and integrating provisions for improved preparedness, building back better, addressing underlying risk drivers in national and local disaster response, recovery and rehabilitation plans, and promoting investment in multi-hazard early-warning mechanisms.

Reducing disaster risk is possible, but it calls for collective commitments to sociocultural change, a culture of prevention and the central role of integrated disaster risk management in building the world we value and desire. We do know better, and we can and must do more. We cannot choose a path of timidity, maintaining business as usual. Doing so presents us with threats that not only jeopardize sustainable development, but also our very existence.

The year 2023 is the year for course correction. As the Secretary-General said,

“We have the information we need. We have the tools and technology. What we need is the political will to forge a peace pact with nature and transform

how we grow food, use land, fuel transport, and power economies.”

Let us not squander this opportunity. The time is now. Let us rise to the occasion, apply what we have learned and ensure risk-informed decision-making, investment and behaviour in all societies so that current and future generations have a future filled not with fear, but with hope.

The President: I thank Ms. Mizutori for her statement.

I also wish to thank the Deputy Secretary-General for taking the time to be with us this morning; she will have to leave now due to her other commitments.

I now give the floor to Ms. Singano.

Ms. Singano: The year 2015 was a very historic year for me, and I am sure it probably was also for most of the people in this Hall. On my own account, 2015 brought this amazing wave of collective optimism — a sense of renewed hope — which gave us courage to dream and envision a new world, a world where disasters can be prevented, or the impact can be minimized, a world where no one will be left behind, regardless of where they live or the circumstances of their birth, a world where climate injustices will come to an end and planetary health will be restored. In March 2015, the Sendai Framework was adopted, in September of that year, the Sustainable Development Goals were adopted (resolution 70/1), and, in December 2015, the Paris Agreement was adopted. While a lot can be said about the lost opportunities on making these decisions and frameworks stronger and better, we have these frameworks and as of now these frameworks are crucial pillars of our collective vision.

Today we are gathered in this Hall to review the implementation of the Sendai Framework, seven years down the line. In 2015, I was an activist, as I am today. But, in 2015, I, together with other activists, crisscrossed Africa, where my roots are, and which is the continent that is closest to my heart. In our crisscrossing of the continent, we created awareness, mobilized communities to engage with their Governments and supported women in engaging in these global processes. Today I stand in this Hall, on this stage, to speak to the General Assembly, our leaders. In fact, I am in this Hall not just to speak to the General Assembly, but to appeal to it, to get the work done.

The report of the midterm review of the implementation of Sendai Framework screams to us that the work has not been done to the scale or at the pace required to deal with the magnitude of risk communities and countries face daily. It and the related report of the main findings and recommendations of the midterm review (A/77/640) say with clarity that those who need the support the most continue to be systematically left behind. Further, importantly, the report confirms the ongoing cry of non-State actors that the whole-of-society approach has yet to be achieved.

Having a framework is a great milestone, and we need to celebrate that. But having this framework implemented in full by all stakeholders is critical for our shared humanity. My personal concern is that we will not be able to fully implement the Sendai Framework and other agreed frameworks if we constantly choose to do what is easy. Let me take this opportunity to remind the Assembly of the words of Nelson Mandela:

“There is no passion to be found in playing small, in settling for a life that is less than the one [we] are capable of living.”

We need to find pride and joy in doing the hard work.

Recentring global power is not easy. Challenging engraved traditions that push women and girls into endless cycles of vulnerability is not easy. Challenging our own biases and privileges is not easy. Creating just equal, sustainable and resilient societies is not easy. It is hard work, but it is necessary work. It is the right work to do for the sake of our humanity.

In my view, there is no escape from doing the hard work. The only choice we have is either we do the hard work now or we do the hard work later. We can reach and engage women and girls to build their resilience now, or we can bury them with numbers. We can support communities’ disaster risk reduction now or we can mobilize an untenable amount for humanitarian aid. We can make financing available to least developed countries and small island developing States now, or we face the catastrophe of wiping sovereign States off the face of the universe.

Later comes with a significant cost. The good news is that women, whom I represent, and communities, are already providing the leadership needed to get the hard work done. We only need to do our part to connect and support them.

I cannot overemphasize the need to scale up implementation of the Sendai Framework for our own collective resilience. Disasters are not natural, it has been said over and over again, and disasters know no borders. Those who are at the periphery of power, of course, will be affected first and potentially severely. But make no mistake, at the end of the day, we will all be affected.

As we leave these halls of power, can we recommit to getting things done? Can we recommit to scaling up investment to countries and communities that need them the most? Can we strengthen collaboration between countries but also between groups and can we engage in the development and implementation of the gender action plan? Last but not least, can we centre the whole-of-society approach and the whole-of-Government approach everywhere?

It has been said courage can be contagious. Can our leaders be courageous so that we can all be?

The President: I thank Ms. Singano for her statement.

I now give the floor to Mr. Kiliñç.

Mr. Kiliñç: My name is Mustafa Kemal Kiliñç. I am 23 years old. I am a third-year international relations student from Hatay, Türkiye. Participants may know the name of my hometown, Hatay, because it bore the most damage when earthquakes struck Türkiye on 6 February. I am addressing the General Assembly today as a survivor of those devastating natural disasters. I would like to share with the Assembly my first-hand experience.

I was in Hatay visiting my family. I was supposed to go back to my university in the city of Adana the next day. It was 4:17 a.m. Very strong tremors woke me up from a deep sleep. My bed was shaking hard. When I tried to get up, the ground was shaking so violently that I felt it was going to swallow me up. At first, I thought I was dreaming. As I struggled to gain my balance, tremors became even stronger. I realized I was in the middle of a powerful earthquake.

Furniture started to fall, windows broke, walls cracked, and plaster fell off. There was destruction all around us. My family and I were all confused and scared, but we had each other to reach safety. It was a horrible experience that made me feel very helpless and vulnerable.

We left our building safely. The powerful earthquake finally stopped, but the aftershocks continued. Each one triggered greater fear. We searched for a safe place to take shelter. It was a race against time because we did not know when the next wave would hit us or if it would be even stronger.

When the sun came up, we saw the extent of the destruction around us more clearly. Countless buildings were in ruins, and people were on the streets, homeless. Not only was my hometown, Hatay, struck, but ten more provinces in Türkiye were directly hit by the earthquake. In my city, the physical destruction was heaviest, with 14,000 buildings destroyed. An additional 70,000 buildings suffered heavy damage. Imagine one out of every five buildings in Manhattan being totally destroyed.

Some of the places from my childhood memories now no longer exist. I am in this Hall today because our building did not collapse. It did not collapse because our contractor had applied high standards that made the building earthquake resistant. Nevertheless, we could not go back to our home, as the aftershocks continued and basic services like water and electricity were not available. We lived in our car for a week. There were seven of us. We mostly felt cold inside the car because we could only start the engine from time to time. If we ran out of gas, we could not get more.

We were grateful for the blankets they gave us. We were lucky to be able to stay in a train wagon for another week. There, we finally felt warm. Eventually we moved across the country to stay with some relatives. We returned to Hatay after a few weeks to try to build our lives back again.

In the days following the earthquakes, we were always torn between the joy of good news and the sadness of bad news. For several days we could not reach many friends and relatives by phone. We were not sure who lived and who died. We would be happy when we found out that someone was alive. We even experienced miracles: five of our relatives were rescued after 1,020 hours under the rubble. They stayed alive thanks to the two-litre bottles of water that were next to their beds. But then we were crushed when we heard the news of deaths. I lost many close and distant relatives, as well as dear friends and teachers who are never coming back.

In total, more than 50,000 people lost their lives in our country as a result of these earthquakes. Almost half of these dead were in my city. Getting their dead

bodies out of the rubble was also a challenge. We waited for hours and even days to give them a proper burial. When we received their remains, we felt relief. We went through a range of extreme emotions in a period of days.

We also saw disasters on top of disasters. Fires that broke out at the seaports because of collapsed containers took days to extinguish. There were also fires on the streets. Many survivors lived on the streets in the middle of the dust and rubble, suffering from the cold weather and heavy rain. Then that rain turned into floods, killing more people and causing more destruction. Within just a few days, we endured earthquakes, fires and floods. It made us wonder whether this was the apocalypse. The earthquakes struck an area as large as many of the countries represented in this Assembly. Right after the earthquakes, roads and railways collapsed, making transportation difficult.

It was therefore impossible for the authorities to provide significant assistance right away. At first, all the victims relied on each other to remove the rubble, save others and provide aid. When our authorities, non-governmental organizations and volunteers from many countries around the world mobilized to help, it lifted our spirits.

We saw many foreign search-and-rescue teams on the streets. They were assisting Turkish officials. We also saw United Nations vehicles and staff. On behalf of all the earthquake victims, I would like to express our deepest gratitude to all the nations that supported us in these difficult days.

We cannot predict natural disasters. But we can certainly be prepared whenever and wherever they happen. This is why I wanted to tell my story. I want people to understand what a disaster victim feels and experiences. I hope that as a result of the work at the United Nations there will be fewer disaster victims like me around the world.

The President: I thank Mr. Kiliç for his heartening and humbling statement.

The General Assembly will now proceed to consider draft resolution A/77/L.70. As stated in my letter dated 12 May 2023, considering the long list of inscribed speakers for the plenary segment, I strongly encourage delegations to include any explanation of position concerning the political declaration in

their statements in the plenary, rather than making a statement in explanation of position at this stage.

The Assembly will now take a decision on draft resolution A/77/L.70, entitled “Political declaration of the mid-term review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction (2015–2030)”.

May I take it that the Assembly decides to adopt draft resolution A/77/L.70?

Draft resolution A/77/L.70 was adopted (resolution 77/289).

The President: Before giving the floor in explanation of position after adoption, I would like to remind delegations that explanations are limited to 10 minutes and should be made by representatives from their seats.

I now give the floor to the representative of the Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela.

Ms. Marin Sevilla (Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela) (*spoke in Spanish*): The Bolivarian Republic of Venezuela has the honour of taking the floor on behalf of the Group of Friends in Defence of the Charter of the United Nations. At the outset, we appreciate the efforts of Australia and Indonesia in facilitating the negotiations of the recently adopted consensus document (resolution 77/289). However, we wish to place the following on record.

First, the debate on disaster risk reduction is taking place amid a multifaceted global crisis that is having a devastating impact especially on developing countries and which obligates us to effectively address, inter alia, the increasing frequency and intensity of disasters, given their severe and negative economic, social and environmental consequences.

Secondly, if we recognize that the Sendai Framework is an integral part of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, it is necessary to understand that its full implementation is part of our common efforts to, inter alia, adopt a risk-based approach to sustainable development. The Sendai Framework is therefore part of the same 2030 Agenda that calls on States to refrain from unilaterally enacting and implementing economic, financial and trade measures that are inconsistent with international law and the Charter of the United Nations and which impede the full achievement of economic and social development, particularly in developing countries.

However, how can we really talk about the full and effective implementation of the 2030 Agenda and the Sendai Framework when more than 30 countries around the world, including many in our Group of Friends, are prevented from effectively moving forward in implementing disaster risk reduction programmes or accessing the necessary funds to address the consequences of disasters of various kinds? It must be recognized that unilateral coercive measures also pose obstacles to, inter alia, capacity-building, technical and financial assistance and much-needed technology transfer. It is therefore rather worrisome that, despite the fact that this is a widely known reality, we have chosen in the outcome document of this high-level meeting to remain silent on this vital issue for more than a third of humanity.

In that context, we underline the urgent need for all means and enabling conditions for disaster risk reduction and implementation of the Sendai Framework at the local and national levels, as well as addressing situations of risk and vulnerability, while promoting the resilience of people and communities. To this end, it is imperative to put a complete and unconditional end to the application of unilateral coercive measures that not only cause severe pain to our peoples, but also hinder the very implementation of the Sendai Framework.

Accordingly, our Group of Friends considers the recently adopted document to be incomplete and that it will remain so until it truly reflects an issue that has a direct impact on the development of billions of people. Unilateral coercive measures are an unfortunate reality that can no longer be ignored, especially given the disturbing and growing severity of climate catastrophes in recent years and the obstacles that such measures pose in providing assistance and facilitating care and relief efforts.

The President: I would like to express my sincere appreciation to His Excellency Mr. Mitchell Fifield, Permanent Representative of Australia to the United Nations, and His Excellency Mr. Arrmanatha Nasir, Permanent Representative of Indonesia to the United Nations, who ably and patiently conducted the discussions and complex negotiations in the informal consultations on the political declaration adopted as resolution 77/289. I am sure members of the Assembly will join me in extending to them our sincere appreciation.

As Members are aware, pursuant to resolution 76/204, this high-level meeting also consists of a plenary segment, four interactive multi-stakeholder panels and a closing segment. The plenary segment will take place immediately following this opening segment and will continue until 1 p.m. The plenary segment will resume this afternoon from 3 to 9 p.m. in this Hall. The four multi-stakeholder panels and closing segment will be held in the Trusteeship Council Chamber tomorrow, as announced in the programme.

Before we begin with the list of speakers for the plenary segment, I would like to remind delegations that, as mentioned in my letter dated 11 May, statements will be limited to three minutes for individual delegations and five minutes for statements made on behalf of Groups of States.

I now call on Her Excellency Ms. Katalin Novák, President of Hungary.

President Novák: Europe seemed to be a calm, peaceful continent in the past 70 years. What do we see now? Pandemics, catastrophes, floods, fires and a brutal war in Ukraine. Our European world is not the same as we thought it would be by now. On top of that, we suffer from the sad picture of empty cradles, and we are facing a serious demographic crisis in our Western world.

I am Katalin Novák, the first woman President of Hungary, and I have three reasons to be here with everyone today. First, we Hungarians are affected by the war in our direct neighbour, Ukraine. We are also affected by the demographic decline and challenges we have not faced before. Secondly, we feel compassion for the countries that are more exposed to natural disasters than we are. Thirdly, I am proud to be present at a meeting presided by the Hungarian President of the General Assembly, Mr. Csaba Kőrösi.

Hungary is a middle-sized country in the heart of Europe, with a population of 10 million. We have no seas or significant natural resources. However, given our resources and local conditions, we have made outstanding efforts to help those in need. Through the framework of the Hungary Helps programme alone, since 2017 Hungary has sponsored about 300 humanitarian and rehabilitation projects in 54 countries, the equivalent of more than \$100 million.

On the cold night of 6 February, a 7.8 magnitude earthquake struck Türkiye and Syria and claimed

the lives of about 50,000 people, causing damages in excess of \$100 billion. Hungary was there to help from the first moment. I personally visited President Erdoğan and the Turkish people and flew over Hatay Province, the region most seriously damaged by the catastrophe. I am proud that a total of 167 Hungarian specialists and 29 rescue dogs saved the lives of 35 people. In addition, we provided Türkiye with more than 100 tons of medicine and medical equipment, and we are also providing help to rebuild a cultural centre and a church. We also provided 47 tons of rapid aid, providing care and housing for the Syrian people who were directly affected by the earthquake. And three medical clinical units were deployed in Syria in the most affected regions.

That is just one recent example that shows how important it is to not only protect ourselves, but also to assist each other. That is why we launched the Hungary Helps programme, with a view to providing quick and effective assistance when most needed. We were there to help at the floods in Pakistan last year, and the year before that at the Croatian earthquake, the lethal typhoons and at the eruption of the Mount Nyiragongo volcano.

A final question — for whom do we want to save our planet, if not for the next generation? We need strong families, where we can teach our children to care for their own environment and to help those in need. Together, we can do even more to build a secure and sustainable future. Hungary is ready to help. His Holiness Pope Francis visited Hungary just a few weeks ago and said: “Let us give a future of hope, not war, to the next generations. A future of cradles, not of graves.” May his words become a reality.

The President: I now call on the Vice-President of the Republic of Zambia.

Ms. Nalumango (Zambia): Before I deliver my national statement, allow me to express our solidarity upon the adoption of resolution 77/289, on the political declaration. On behalf of the Government of the Republic of Zambia, we commend the work of the co-Facilitators on the Declaration on the mid-term review of the Sendai Framework and thank all Member States for reaching consensus. The Zambian declaration is in support of the adopted text, which we hope will enable States to accelerate the implementation of the Sendai Framework.

Allow me now to deliver our national statement.

At the outset, I would like to express our gratitude to the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Disaster Risk Reduction for convening this important meeting.

The midterm review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction is taking place at a critical moment in our global development history. We are approaching the midpoint of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), the SDG summit and the global taking stock of the Paris Agreement on Climate Change. And yet, progress recorded so far is very worrisome. We are witnessing the increasing scale, frequency and intensity of climate-induced disasters, with their devastating impacts, undermining the implementation of the 2030 Agenda and the Sustainable Development Goals, more generally. We therefore cannot overemphasize the urgency of accelerating the implementation of the Sendai Framework as an integral part of the 2030 Agenda.

We acknowledge and applaud the Secretary-General's call to protect everyone on earth through the universal coverage of early-warning systems. However, most developing countries lack sufficient investments in forecasting and early-warning systems for effective and comprehensive early action, including disaster preparedness and response.

We call for enhanced international support from development partners in integration of disaster risk reduction in the implementation of relevant sustainable development policies.

Zambia has undertaken the following key measures, among others, to strengthen disaster risk management in the context of the climate change discourse:

First, we established a robust multidimensional disaster-management structure at all levels of society and Government, which allows for the participation of both State and non-State actors in disaster risk management.

Secondly, we incorporated disaster risk reduction into development planning in order to ensure that the national development framework is risk-informed.

In conclusion, as Chair of the African Group of Negotiators on Climate Change, we also look forward to a constructive engagement on funding arrangements for addressing loss and damage at the twenty-

eighth conference of the parties to the united nations framework convention on climate change.

The President: I now give the floor to the Prime Minister of the Cooperative Republic of Guyana.

Mr. Phillips (Guyana): My delegation aligns itself with the statements to be delivered on behalf of the Caribbean Community, the Alliance of Small Island States and the Group of 77 and China.

Under the theme “Working together to reduce risk for a resilient future”, the high-level midterm review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015—2030 is being held at a critical time for us in Latin America and the Caribbean. Our region is the second-most disaster-prone region of the world. Between 1997 and 2017, one out of four disasters and just over 50 per cent of the economic losses due to climate-related disasters occurred in Latin America and the Caribbean. Climate change is exacerbating the impacts of natural hazards, with rising sea levels and more frequent and intense weather events.

More needs to be done to address the underlying risk drivers that contribute to disasters. International cooperation and support are critical for reducing vulnerability to disaster, including for providing financial and technical assistance, sharing best practices, promoting knowledge exchange and capacity-building. Since the adoption of the Sendai Framework, we have made modest progress in implementing disaster risk reduction measures. Nationally, Guyana’s Low Carbon Development Strategy 2030 includes building resilience to the impacts of climate change, improving disaster risk management and promoting adaptation measures in vulnerable communities. Regionally, the Caribbean Disaster Emergency Management Agency established the Regional Comprehensive Disaster Management Strategy and Programming Framework 2014–2024, which aims to strengthen disaster risk governance and reduce the vulnerability of the region to disasters. The Strategy is highly recognized and valued, by participating States and partners alike, as the overarching framework and basis for coordination and collaboration to advance disaster risk management and resilience across the region.

Despite our efforts, we in Latin America and the Caribbean continue to face significant challenges in reducing disaster risk. Again, the main challenge is the limited financial and technical resources available to our countries to implement disaster risk reduction

measures, which limits our ability to invest in the infrastructure and systems needed to reduce our vulnerability to disasters.

The classification of many small island developing States as middle-income countries has impeded their access to concessional financing, which is critical for their overall development, including building resilience. We therefore look forward to the early completion of the United Nations multidimensional vulnerability index, which will objectively determine our countries’ vulnerability and resilience and go beyond the narrow criterion of gross domestic product for the allocation of financial support to developing countries. We also look forward to the speedy establishment of the loss and damage fund, which will be critical for the countries that are most vulnerable and most affected by the effects of climate change. We also call for the \$100 billion per year commitment to the developing world to be urgently implemented.

It is those countries that contribute the least to climate change that are most affected by it. It is therefore not a matter of charity but of climate justice when we ask for commitments to be fulfilled. Climate justice is a comprehensive approach that addresses the underlying drivers of climate change and promotes equity and fairness in the distribution of the benefits and costs of climate action. Climate justice and international solidarity are important for addressing the challenges of climate change and the promotion of sustainable development.

I end my remarks with a call for everyone in every nation to work towards meeting their commitments to the Sendai Framework. Guyana will continue to do its part.

The President: I now give the floor to the Prime Minister and Minister for Education and Training, Minister for Police, Fire Services and Emergency Services, and Minister for His Majesty’s Armed Forces of the Kingdom of Tonga.

Mr. Sovaleni (Tonga): I am pleased to attend the high-level meeting of the General Assembly on the midterm review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015—2030, which gives us an opportunity to take stock of national progress, challenges and innovative solutions in achieving anticipated goals under the Sendai Framework.

I acknowledge the successful conclusion of the negotiation process on the political declaration of the high-level meeting on the midterm review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction (resolution 77/289), which was ably co-facilitated by the Ambassadors and Permanent Representatives of Australia and Indonesia. Tonga supports the declaration and its adoption.

We reaffirm our commitment to the full implementation of the Sendai Framework, and I am confident that the outcome of today's high-level meeting will allow us to identify innovative solutions and gaps in policy and practice, particularly in recognition of the changing risk landscapes due to the growing rate of intense climate-related hazards.

Tonga has made progress in the implementation of projects in areas pertaining to understanding disaster risk, strengthening governance to better manage disaster risk, investing in disaster risk reduction for resilience and enhancing disaster preparedness for effective response. That is also in alignment with our region's 2050 Strategy for the Blue Pacific Continent.

Despite that progress, Tonga continues to be severely affected by climate-related hazards. We have been fighting to survive the brunt of climate-related disasters, despite being negligible contributors to the climate crisis. As reported, no country is on track to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals by 2030 due to obstacles that include intensifying catastrophic natural disasters, the coronavirus disease pandemic, geopolitical tensions, and technical and human capacity constraints.

Evidently, there are significant gaps in accessing financial resources for initiatives targeted towards strengthening governance and institutional capacities. That is also a major challenge for most Pacific small island developing States. The current disaster-related financing regime is largely driven by reactive and compensatory investments for post-disaster response, all of which hinders progress.

In January last year, thousands of families were displaced because of the Hunga Tonga-Hunga Ha'apai volcanic eruption and the ensuing tsunami. That once-in-a-1000-year event was reported to be a magma hammer, which generated the largest atmospheric explosion recorded by modern instruments. Our hard-won development gains were swept away by a single event. The outpaced capacities of our communities

and Governments to anticipate and manage disasters is worrisome. The damage to the economy from that eruption and tsunami was estimated by the World Bank to be approximately equivalent to 30 per cent of Tonga's gross domestic product.

Accordingly, we need effective integrated climate change adaptation and disaster risk reduction efforts that will enhance resilience. We need more investments in understanding the underlying drivers of the social construction of risk. We need disaster risk reduction interventions that are targeted towards strengthening governance and institutional capacities. The outcome of the midterm review process should therefore focus on contextualizing the processes of risk-informing development initiatives through targeted investments. However, that cannot be achieved if investments and resources are allocated on a piecemeal basis. We need an inclusive and holistic approach to financing disaster risk reduction interventions, including the loss and damage facility.

To conclude, Tonga calls for a review of the financing disaster regime and the implementation system that will localize solutions for effective disaster risk reduction as we look forward to engaging constructively with all delegations over the next two days. The review of the Sendai Framework and the political declaration thereon should guide us on the right pathway to meet the noble objectives of the Sendai Framework.

The President: I now give the floor to the Deputy Prime Minister of Eswatini.

Mr. Masuku (Eswatini): The Kingdom of Eswatini is appreciative of today's high-level meeting on the midterm review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015—2030, at which we will reflect on the progress of countries in implementing that important Framework. There is no doubt that the Sendai Framework has brought together a large number of stakeholders to work at the local and international levels. It is a collaborative effort that will accelerate risk reduction and build a resilient future.

Financing disaster risk management is undoubtedly one of the biggest challenges for a country with a small economy, such as ours. Inadequate financing slows down the implementation of disaster risk management plans and leaves everyone vulnerable, even when the risk is known and can be prevented. While our country is on course to develop a disaster risk management fund, there are already concerns that it may not be adequately

capitalized to meet the cost of loss and damage caused by the impact of climate change. That calls for climate change and disaster risk reduction practitioners and institutions to work together to prevent duplication and maximize the use of limited resources.

Eswatini will further institutionalize systemic-risk monitoring through the development of a disaster risk management monitoring framework, as well as through the implementation of the Global Risk Assessment Framework, in collaboration with the United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction (UNDRR). Eswatini will continue to work with UNDRR and the Southern African Development Community to improve the understanding of risk, which is one of the priorities of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction. It will also launch a national platform for disaster risk reduction, which will ensure the active and meaningful participation of communities and all sectors of our community or economy in disaster risk reduction.

The Kingdom of Eswatini has accomplished numerous achievements emanating from the implementation of the Sendai Framework, including the formulation of the national resilience strategy, the tropical cyclone readiness plan, the mobilization of stakeholders to improve disaster preparedness and the inclusion of disaster risk reduction in nationally determined contributions. The impact of climate change, manifested through prolonged dry spells, flooding and heatwaves, accompanied by a high rate of unemployment, has led to at least 20 per cent of the population living in chronic food insecurity.

The Government has for a long time provided safety nets to the population through cash-based transfers. Although that is necessary and helpful in the short term, it is not sustainable and therefore poses one of the biggest challenges for the country in sustainably tackling the cause of chronic food insecurity, which we understand to be the impact of climate change. To build resilience, several other programmes that target chronically vulnerable populations have been initiated. One of them, the Child Headed Households Farming programme, which is a Government initiative supported by various stakeholders, is already yielding impressive results. The most vulnerable child-headed households are supplied with farm inputs and assisted with the planting of fruit trees to produce their own food. However, they still need irrigation equipment to be resilient to drought.

The Kingdom of Eswatini recognizes that disaster risk management should be part of government policy and programmes, as sustainable development will be elusive without it. In that regard, disaster risk reduction has been included in the Water Management Policy of 2017, the 2019 National Drought Management Plan, the 2022 National Development Plan and many other government plans.

In an effort to achieve the Sendai Framework's targets and priorities, the Kingdom of Eswatini is currently reviewing the Disaster Management Act of 2006, which will strengthen disaster governance to manage disaster risk. That review is informed by the prevailing knowledge and best practices globally, as well as our own experience gathered over the past seven years. The 2015–2016 drought, the coronavirus disease (COVID-19) and the recurring cyclones, the intensity and return periods of which have been amplified as a result of climate change, left us with rich knowledge to use towards a better and risk-resilient future.

Thousands of housing structures for the elderly and child-headed families were destroyed by torrential rainfall and tropical cyclones. The country has raised awareness on the importance of adhering to building codes and has also constructed at least 800 improved housing structures in the building-back-to-better effort. The country witnessed strong collaboration among its security forces, health sector, private sector and religious groups, which proved to be effective during the joint emergency operations to respond to the coronavirus disease pandemic. We consider that collaboration to be a best practice in curtailing rapid onset disasters.

On behalf of the people of the Kingdom of Eswatini and His Majesty's Government, I would like to thank the United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction and our international partners for their support in advancing disaster risk reduction in our country. I would like to thank you, Mr. President, for the opportunity to learn in such a forum, as it will strengthen our knowledge and resolve on disaster risk reduction.

The President: I now give the floor to the Minister of Education, Sustainable Development, Innovation, Science, Technology and Vocational Training of Saint Lucia.

Mr. Edward (Saint Lucia): The member States of the Caribbean Community (CARICOM) have long experienced disproportionate challenges in terms of

sustainable development, owing to our geography, small size and open economies, which leave us exposed and highly vulnerable to external shocks. We also face elevated risks in terms of disaster incidence and consequences, particularly in the realms of climate change, sea level rise and natural disasters, including hurricanes, earthquakes and volcanoes.

As entirely or predominantly coastal nations, the concentration of population, agricultural land, civil infrastructure and economic development in the coastal zones exacerbates our inherent vulnerability to natural disasters. The Caribbean Disaster Emergency Management Agency utilizes the Regional Comprehensive Disaster Management Strategy as the Caribbean's vehicle for the implementation of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030. Its overarching framework forms the basis for coordination and collaboration to advance disaster risk management and resilience across our region.

We are at the midpoint of the implementation of the 2015 agreements, and progress has stalled and in some cases reversed. Let us be clear — that has resulted not only from the impact of the coronavirus disease pandemic but also from a weakened multilateral system and the lack of progress in addressing climate change. Our economies have been hard hit, and we are at the tipping point of unsustainable debt. A marked increase in inequalities and barriers between risk science, perception and risk-informed decision-making further compounds our vulnerability. Against that backdrop, the representatives of CARICOM member States arrive at this high-level meeting of the General Assembly on the midterm review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030 with one clear message — there is considerable work yet to be done. Urgent course correction is an imperative.

Risks are being created and are accumulating faster than our ability to anticipate, manage and reduce them. They bring increasingly dire consequences for people, livelihoods, society and the ecosystems on which we depend. The shared structural disadvantages and characteristics of our member States not only place us at an economic disadvantage by preventing economies of scale but also hinder sustainable development by limiting our ability to recover after a disaster, more so than for larger and more diversified economies. It is therefore the view of CARICOM that in order to generate targeted actions that accelerate progress

towards the Sendai targets in our member States, the following critical priorities must be advanced.

First, we must build resilience to complex multiple hazards and strengthen critical infrastructure, including by improving building codes, retrofitting existing structures and creating more robust communication and emergency systems.

Secondly, we must promote the transfer of technology, including enhanced early-warning systems that can quickly and effectively alert people to potential hazards by providing accurate and timely information. That includes building up emergency broadcasting and alert systems and ensuring that people know what to do in the event of a natural disaster. In that vein, CARICOM welcomes the Secretary-General's Early Warnings For All initiative and is pleased that the first regional launch of that initiative in the world took place in the Caribbean in February.

Thirdly, we need improved disaster preparedness and response plans, in particular by providing training and capacity-building in emergency responses, building up emergency supplies and infrastructure, and putting in place systems to coordinate disaster-response efforts that include interventions to scale up national and regional human capacity.

Fourthly, climate change adaptation is critical, as CARICOM countries must adapt to cope with the impacts of climate change, including by implementing measures to promote renewable energy sources and planning for rising sea levels.

Fifthly, we must build community resilience by empowering people and local actors to prepare for and respond to natural disasters, promote community-led disaster risk reduction initiatives and ensure that vulnerable populations are supported.

Mr. Kimani (Kenya), Vice-President, took the Chair.

Sixthly, the scaling-up of disaster risk financing across the region is essential and is inextricably linked to the broader conversation on the needed reform of international development financing and the international financial system. Those reforms must take into account, in the context of disaster risk reduction, how vulnerability is assessed when accessing development financing. The ongoing discussions on the creation of a multidimensional vulnerability index and the Bridgetown Initiative can lend support to the scaling-up of disaster risk financing.

If we are to realize meaningful progress, those six priority actions should be solidified in the relevant instruments that would enable implementation, including the new sustainable development blueprint for small island developing States, which will be adopted at the fourth International Conference on Small Island Developing States, to be hosted by Antigua and Barbuda in 2024.

We have adopted a political declaration (resolution 77/289) that reaffirms our collective commitment to the full implementation of the Sendai Framework, including its guiding principles. Let us ensure they do not remain mere words on paper but are translated to real-world, tangible actions towards our shared goals. CARICOM remains a committed partner and is prepared to work with all to ensure the full and meaningful implementation of the Sendai Framework.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Commissioner for Crisis Management of the European Union.

Mr. Lenarčič (European Union): The candidate countries, Türkiye, North Macedonia, Montenegro, Albania, Ukraine, the Republic of Moldova, Bosnia and Herzegovina, the potential candidate country Georgia, as well as Andorra, align themselves with this statement.

We meet at a time of more dangers than ever before. The risk landscape has changed profoundly since the launch of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030 in 2015. The list is long and is growing despite our best efforts. The fragilities exposed by the coronavirus disease pandemic, the disastrous impacts of the climate crisis — including the more intense and frequent extreme weather events — and the man-made disasters and conflicts in tandem with natural disasters such as earthquakes — those are huge challenges, and we must rise to meet them. That is why it is so important to be here today for the midterm review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030.

On behalf of the European Union (EU) and its member States, we would like to thank the Secretary-General, the President of the General Assembly and the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Disaster Risk Reduction and Head of the United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction for providing this opportunity for reflection and recommitment.

What have we accomplished by placing resilience at the centre of our policymaking? First, we have faced the climate crisis head on. Within the framework of the European Green Deal, we have adopted initiatives to scale up climate change mitigation and adaptation, strengthen biodiversity protections and tackle pollution. Secondly, we have planned ahead. By developing our strategic foresight capacities, we can better anticipate trends, potential risks and opportunities. Thirdly, we have become more prepared. By strengthening our Union Civil Protection Mechanism, we have improved our disaster risk management and have demonstrated EU solidarity at its best.

Those actions are not limited to Europe. We have stepped up our cooperation with partner countries in the area of disaster risk reduction, saving lives across the world. But that is not enough. As we reflect here today on the road ahead, we know that we must do more. The world is not on track to achieve the objectives of the Sendai Framework. As we look today towards 2030, we must use this moment to recommit our energies and spare no effort in reaching our goals. The EU is working hard to make that happen. Let me share with members of the General Assembly just four of the ways in which we are doing that.

The first way is disaster resilience. We are strengthening our resilience in Europe thanks to the adoption — with our member States — of a new European disaster resilience agenda and five disaster resilience goals, which will also guide our policy dialogue with our partner countries, improving resilience worldwide.

The second way is disaster preparedness. We will strengthen preparedness for all countries, including the most vulnerable. We will contribute to the Early Warnings for All Initiative of the Secretary-General, with several EU member States announcing new commitments to initiatives, such as the Climate Risk and Early Warning System Initiative and the Systematic Observations Financing Facility. Robust early warnings will enable us to scale up anticipatory and early action.

The third way involves funding. We will continue to increase funding for adaptation and climate resilience, with a focus on the most vulnerable countries and building back better. We look forward to engaging constructively in the implementation of the new funding arrangements responding to loss and damage, including through climate and disaster risk

financing and insurance mechanisms. In that way, we will strengthen our response to the risks of loss and damage driven by the climate crisis in those countries.

The fourth way concerns cooperation. By strengthening the synergies linking development, climate and humanitarian assistance, as well as the better management of natural resources, we can address the root causes of disasters. That is key to building community-level resilience and ensuring that no one is left behind. We must ensure that the Framework is implemented coherently with other respective agendas. We must also work together to tackle displacement and migration related to disasters, with a focus on prevention, resilience and adaptation.

We have come very far, but there is still a very long way to go. We cannot prevent all disasters. That is why we must prepare for the worst, while striving for the best. The Framework is much more than a set of targets — it means a better, safer and more resilient future for people across the world. Together, we can achieve that. Together, we must achieve that.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Minister for Rural and Maritime Development and Disaster Management of Fiji.

Mr. Ditoka (Fiji): I have the honour to deliver the following remarks on behalf of the members of the Pacific Islands Forum with presence at the United Nations. We acknowledge the guidance and support of the Cook Islands as Chair of the Pacific Islands Forum.

Since the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030 was introduced, there has been a growing recognition that disaster risk reduction requires an inclusive and multi-stakeholder approach. In the Blue Pacific continent, key enablers include a strong political commitment, the recognition of disaster risk reduction as a key priority and the need to collaborate among ourselves and with the wider global community in order to advance our disaster reduction efforts. Through our Framework for Resilient Development in the Pacific and its inclusive Pacific Resilience Partnership, we have sought to translate the global principles and objectives of the Sendai Framework into actionable measures that are tailored to the Pacific island context. Pacific countries have invested in technology and systems in order to detect and monitor natural hazards, enabling timely alerts and responses. Improved capabilities for forecasting cyclones, tsunamis and other hazards have enabled early and anticipatory action that has saved

countless lives and facilitated efficient evacuation procedures, underscoring the effectiveness of such initiatives. Anticipatory action is helping us to understand when to act and where to focus action and preparatory interventions.

Forum leaders have declared that the Pacific faces a climate emergency that threatens the livelihoods, security and well-being of its people and ecosystems. More than ever, the integration of climate change adaptation measures into disaster risk reduction strategies is crucial to ensure that our region is prepared for the climate-related challenges that lie ahead. Yet, financing for disaster risk reduction and climate action in the Pacific is still not at the level at which it needs to be. The Pacific faces resource constraints, including limited financial resources, technical expertise and infrastructure. Going forward, we need to connect the lessons of the Sendai midterm review process with the preparatory process for the fourth International Conference on Small Island Developing States in order to ensure that the future Programme of Action for the Sustainable Development of Small Island Developing States is underpinned by resilience. In that regard, we note the work of the High-Level Panel on the Development of a Multidimensional Vulnerability Index for Small Island Developing States.

Our Blue Pacific continent needs reliable and timely climate and disaster risk information that can easily be accessed and understood. Such information should take into account future demographic, economic and climate scenarios, and should localize risk information. In addition to the voluntary national reviews undertaken by a few Pacific island countries to inform the midterm review of the Sendai Framework, several thematic reports were commissioned at the regional level to highlight the regional aspects of key issues, including on gender on the pathway for community resilience, disability inclusion, climate- and disaster-resilient infrastructure, and traditional and indigenous knowledge. We have shared the findings of those reviews and reports in order to inform the midterm review and ensure that the lessons learned, challenges faced and opportunities identified from our Blue Pacific region are incorporated and reflected in the actions to amplify and accelerate risk-informed action.

I would now like to make some remarks in my national capacity as the minister responsible for disaster management.

Fiji has made modest progress towards the achievement of the priorities and targets of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction. We have reduced our disaster-related mortality by more than 11 per cent since 2016 and have strengthened the collaboration among stakeholders for the mainstreaming of disaster risk reduction into socioeconomic and development processes. We attribute that to our commitment to ensuring a whole-of-Government and whole-of-society approach towards disaster risk management, so that the voices of the most vulnerable and exposed to disaster risk are taken into consideration in the design and implementation of disaster risk reduction strategies and policies. We firmly believe that disaster risk governance mechanisms that transfer responsibility and accountability to local authorities and communities is key to ensuring that people are at the heart of decision-making and ensuring that people take ownership of managing and reducing their risks related to natural and man-made hazards.

Disaster risk financing remains one of the key challenges for small island developing States such as ours. We have noted the ongoing emphasis on the financing of post-disaster response and recovery, instead of the recommended ideal of funding support being channelled towards pre-disaster preventative measures. Furthermore, enhancing data collection and analysis is a critical area that requires continued support. Improving data-collection systems and investing in advanced technology for monitoring and early-warning systems can significantly enhance risk-assessment capabilities. By collecting comprehensive and accurate data on hazards, vulnerabilities and exposure, decision-makers can gain a better understanding of the risks faced by small island developing States.

We note with appreciation the improvements in the general understanding of disaster risk and the methodologies and tools now available for disaster risk assessments. However, we maintain that we need to unlock the resources and expertise that lie within the private sector and bring to the fore the knowledge and insights available within communities, in particular when it comes to understanding and addressing the underlying contributory factors of disaster risk. In order to promote risk-informed investments, it is crucial to enhance partnerships between the private and public sectors, which involves incentivizing collaboration and transforming economic and financial systems and processes. One essential step is to make risk-

informed decision-making and reporting mandatory for both Government- and private-sector investments. In recognizing the significance of such an approach, Fiji has taken a proactive stance by establishing the Fiji Business Disaster Resilience Council, which serves as a platform for fostering private-public partnerships, enabling joint efforts to address disaster risks and building resilience.

If anything, the coronavirus disease has taught us that the traditional linear way of thinking about disaster risk management is now a thing of the past. We must come to terms with the interconnectedness of the global community and the potential transboundary impacts and non-linear nature of systemic risk. In the ever-changing risk landscape that is compounded daily by the impacts of climate change, we are confronted more than ever with challenges that will affect us all, whether the origin of the problem be domestic or international in nature. It is my considered opinion that, moving forward, we must renew our focus on national priorities by building resilience into our economic, financial, infrastructural, social and environmental systems, and that a thorough understanding of the interplay and relationships among the systems will help us to make decisions that will strengthen the overall resilience of our respective countries.

The Fiji Government would like to assure the United Nations and the global community that we will continue to do our part in the global effort to reduce the impacts of disasters. We acknowledge the invaluable role of traditional knowledge in disaster response. Indigenous and local communities possess unique knowledge and practices that have enabled them to adapt to and cope with natural hazards for centuries. In our disaster risk reduction efforts, we commit to respecting, preserving and integrating traditional knowledge into our strategies and plans. We express our support for the implementation of the gender action plan, acknowledging the disproportionate impact of disasters on women, which can be attributed to social and cultural norms, economic disparities and unequal access to resources. By recognizing and supporting women's roles in disaster risk reduction, we take a significant step towards a more equitable and resilient society.

I would like to conclude by taking this opportunity to inform the General Assembly that Fiji recently published its Sendai Framework midterm review report, which provides an in-depth analysis and valuable

insight into the effective strategies and initiatives implemented by Fiji to mitigate risks and enhance resilience in diverse sectors. By showcasing success stories, identifying challenges and highlighting areas for improvement, the report strives to foster inspiration and facilitate the exchange of knowledge among countries and organizations committed to disaster risk reduction. I thank members for the opportunity to update the Assembly and wish us all well as we continue to build towards the successful realization of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction by 2030.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Minister of Land and Environment of Mozambique.

Ms. Maibaze (Mozambique): We are honoured to convey the greetings of Mr. Filipe Jacinto Nyusi, President of Mozambique and African Union Champion for Disaster Risk Reduction, a title which the African Union conferred upon him in recognition of the disaster risk management capacity demonstrated in Mozambique.

Due to its geographic location, Mozambique has been affected from 2015 to the current year by a total of 11 tropical cyclones that had a severe impact on the national economy, leading to loss of human lives and damage to critical infrastructure. As we are aware of the country's level of vulnerability, the Government has adopted specific legal frameworks and strategies for disaster risk management and has implemented global and regional management instruments, including the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030. During the past seven years, in implementing the Sendai Framework, the country has made important achievements, above all, in strengthening legal frameworks and policies. In that regard, we would like to highlight the following achievements.

We adopted and expanded early-warning systems and developed preventive actions. We strengthened multisectoral coordination units at all levels. We established the Disaster Management Fund, which receives an annual disbursement from the Government from tax revenues, aimed at disaster prevention, response and post-disaster reconstruction. During the rainy and cyclone season that just ended, for the first time ever the Government purchased cyclone insurance, which covers damage caused by associated precipitation, the first disbursement of which will respond to the damage caused by category 3 Cyclone Freddy of March, which affected 1.3 million people.

Mozambique is committed to its regional strategic alliances. In that regard, the country hosts the Emergency and Humanitarian Operations Centre of the Southern African Development Community — a mechanism intended to respond to emergency situations in the region. In addition, among other priorities, the country is also committed to improving its capacity in the institutional, technical and financial areas of disaster risk governance, the improvement of local disaster prevention, response and reconstruction capacities, encouraging the building and rebuilding of resilient public infrastructure and strengthening regional and international collaboration.

As I am aware of the role of the countries represented here in finding solutions to reduce the risk of disasters and building a resilient planet, I would like to end my intervention by calling on nations to strengthen cooperation platforms in order to consolidate and operationalize financing mechanisms, such as those that address loss and damage, with a view to reducing the vulnerability of populations and creating the conditions for resilience and adaptation to climate change. In addition, I would like to reiterate our commitment to further strengthening the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction. The political declaration adopted today (resolution 77/289) adds value in that regard, as we recommit ourselves to achieving our common goal by 2030, leaving no one behind.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Minister of Local Government and Rural Development of Jamaica.

Mr. McKenzie (Jamaica): On behalf of the Jamaican delegation, let me express our appreciation to the United Nations for convening this high-level meeting of the General Assembly on the midterm review of the implementation of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030. We thank the President of the General Assembly for his leadership, and we recognize the members of the United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction (UNDRR) for their excellent engagement and extensive work leading up to this successful high-level meeting.

Jamaica recognizes that this high-level meeting provides an immense opportunity for countries, civil society, the private sector and all members of the global disaster risk community to reflect on the findings and recommendations of the midterm review of the Sendai Framework in order to assess progress and address the

challenges in its implementation. It is also an opportunity to identify innovative ways to advance actions in the quest to achieve the seven global targets. As Jamaica is a small island developing State, its vulnerabilities have been further compounded by climate risks and other hazards that have significantly affected our people, economy, infrastructure, environment and culture. The coronavirus disease (COVID-19) pandemic is one such event. The COVID-19 experience also attested to the fact that disasters are systemic and cascading and require an integrated approach that is multisectoral, multidimensional and people-centred, as we adhere to the principle of leaving no one behind.

Jamaica reaffirms its commitment to the implementation of the Sendai Framework to reduce disaster risk through the alignment of its policies, programmes, plans and — by extension — our national plan, Vision 2030. Jamaica has continued to strengthen disaster risk governance and its legislative agenda by adopting a comprehensive disaster risk management policy and plan, which was introduced in Parliament as a green paper and is intended to guide the national disaster management process and structure by using a whole-of-society approach.

In keeping with the Making Cities Resilient 2030 initiative to strengthen our local capacity, the city of Kingston recently adopted the UNDRR Public Health System and Cultural Heritage Addenda to the Disaster Resilience Scorecard for Cities through a workshop supported by the UNDRR. The municipality is well advanced in achieving its disaster-management priorities through an enhanced partnership. The Government of Jamaica is serious about building resilience to counter the financial impact caused by natural hazards. We have therefore improved the country's disaster risk financing programme, which is critical to the overall risk-reduction process.

Jamaica continues to be a major player in the global and regional disaster risk management community. Jamaica called for the name of the Regional Platform for Disaster Reduction in the Americas to be changed to the Regional Platform for Disaster Risk Reduction in the Americas and the Caribbean, which gave greater prominence to the region. In 2021, we were the first country in the Caribbean to host the organization's conference — the seventh Regional Platform for Disaster Risk Reduction in the Americas and the Caribbean. In addition, in 2021, the Regional Platform saw for the first time the inclusion of a youth forum,

with a youth representative at the ministerial and high-level authorities' meeting.

Jamaica continues to build on its disaster-response capabilities by the continuous enhancement of its early-warning systems, which is fundamental to disaster risk reduction, therefore fulfilling the requirements of target (g) of the Sendai Framework — increasing the availability of multi-hazard, early-warning systems and disaster risk information by 2030. The country has received the support of the Government of Japan through the Japan International Cooperation Agency to strengthen its early-warning communication systems and capabilities in order to respond to emergencies and disasters.

In conclusion, the disaster risk reduction measures that the Government of Jamaica is initiating are critical to ensuring the economic viability and survival of our country and its people. We are committed to reducing disaster risk and increasing resilience. As leaders, we must all make a concerted effort to create a pathway to reduce the impact of disasters on our countries by building stronger economies and forging greater partnership with the international community, as we move towards the achievement of the Sustainable Development Goals set out in the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Minister of Justice and Public Security of Norway.

Ms. Mehl (Norway): We are here today to accelerate disaster risk reduction efforts and build resilient societies, which calls for united efforts and strengthened partnerships. The political declaration we adopted today (resolution 77/289) is important for reaching that goal. I want to thank Australia and Indonesia for their outstanding leadership and facilitation of a consensus-based outcome.

At the national level, Norway has always been exposed to a variety of natural hazards. Extreme weather, floods and landslides have caused great damage. And our concern is the increase in both occurrence and impact.

Norwegian municipalities have improved their way of working on disaster risk reduction. Indeed, 99 per cent of all municipalities conduct regular comprehensive risk and vulnerability assessments. Useful lessons from the midterm review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030 will be included in

the Government's new white paper on public security and action plan on adaptation to a changing climate.

Going forward, the private sector will play a key role. In Norway, 90 per cent of critical infrastructure is privately owned. I am convinced that we must continue to encourage and seek new areas and ways to cooperate with the private sector.

At the international level, climate is a priority for Norway. We will double our climate financing towards 2026 and within that triple the support for adaptation and building resilience. We see climate adaptation and disaster risk reduction as key to achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Work under the SDGs, the Paris Agreement and the Sendai Framework must be coordinated and integrated to improve resilience.

Disaster displacement is an increasing challenge. We need to invest in disaster risk reduction, assess potential disaster displacement and prepare for human mobility in a way that minimizes associated risks.

I would like to emphasize the importance of ensuring a gender perspective and a rights-based approach in all our efforts. Stakeholders' participation and a whole-of-society approach are crucial to achieving the Sendai targets.

As one of the co-Chairs, Norway aligns itself with the statement to be presented by my Peruvian colleague on behalf of the Group of Friends for Disaster Risk Reduction.

To conclude, I would like to express my gratitude to the Special Representative of the Secretary-General and to the United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction for the great work they are doing to advance the implementation of the Sendai Framework.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Chair of the Committee for Environmental Protection under the Government of the Republic of Tajikistan.

Mr. Sheralizoda (Tajikistan): I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of the Government of the Republic of Tajikistan at this high-level meeting on the midterm review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030, which provides an opportunity to identify and implement changes, innovations and course corrections in policy, practice, investment and cooperation so as to prevent, mitigate and reduce existing and emerging risks by 2030.

Tajikistan is one of the countries most vulnerable to climate change in the Europe and Central Asia region. Over the past decade, the number of disasters in the country has increased significantly—disasters that have caused enormous socioeconomic and environmental damage, which in turn hinders the achievement by the country of the Sustainable Development Goals. To that end, Tajikistan reaffirms the need for the implementation of the Sendai Framework in the context of achieving the goals and objectives of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

We need concrete actions to address the factors that increase the risk of disasters such as climate change and climate variability, rapid and unplanned urbanization, limitations in technology availability, the unsustainable use of natural resources and pandemics.

The Government of Tajikistan is actively involved in the implementation of the Sendai Framework. In that regard, Tajikistan, in collaboration with the United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction and with the participation of various stakeholders, prepared a report on the midterm review of the implementation of the Sendai Framework. The report showcased the country's achievements in disaster risk reduction and identified priority areas for improvement. Tajikistan, based on the Sendai Framework, has adopted a national disaster risk reduction strategy for the period until 2030 and a midterm programme for the period until 2027 to enhance the strength and resilience capacity legal and institutional framework, conduct surveys in areas exposed to hazardous exogenous processes and to reinforce response activities aimed at providing support to people in emergency situations.

In addition, a national platform for disaster risk reduction was established that brings together various stakeholders.

Despite the significant progress made, a number of areas require concrete action. In order to involve all parties and mobilize additional human and financial resources, it is important to intensify the dialogue among Government agencies, the private sector, civil society and local communities. To protect and ensure the inclusion of all parts of society, it is necessary to strengthen the inclusive approach to raising awareness and understanding of disaster risk and to focus on public engagement in early-warning systems, response and recovery, and development.

One of the important priorities is the issue of the coordination of actions in the field of disaster risk reduction, sustainable development, climate change and water issues. In that regard, I would like to highlight the fact that Tajikistan has been playing an effective role in the context of the global agenda for the past two decades as an advocate for water and climate issues. During that period, at the initiative of Tajikistan, the General Assembly adopted nine resolutions aimed at uniting the international community to address existing water-related issues and intensify actions in that regard.

Remarkably, this year we have the midterm review of the Water Action Decade and the midterm review of the implementation of the Sendai Framework. Utilizing the synergy between both processes will provide an opportunity to identify adjustments that could contribute to the sustainable management of water resources and integrate the lessons learned in disaster risk management, integrated water-resource management and climate adaptation.

We believe that the international community and financial institutions will play a crucial role in achieving tangible results.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Minister of the Interior, Institutional Reform and Democratic Renewal of Belgium.

Ms. Verlinden (Belgium): Belgium is honoured to participate in this high-level meeting of the General Assembly on the midterm review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030. Let me start by stating that Belgium aligns itself with the statement of the European Union, as expressed earlier by Commissioner Lenarčič. Please allow me to add a few considerations from the perspective of Belgium.

The past few years have highlighted the increasing intersectoral and transnational nature of crises. During the major emergencies we have seen, we witnessed more than ever the need for international collaboration and common responses. In the field of disaster risk reduction as well, Belgium firmly believes in the multilateral principles embodied in the United Nations. Of course, the coronavirus disease pandemic immediately comes to mind, but I am also referring to the terrible floods that hit Belgium and its neighbouring countries in the summer of 2021.

Most countries represented here today have faced similar or worse catastrophes over the past few years. In

that challenging context, we are absolutely convinced of the added value of the Sendai Framework and are therefore grateful for the opportunity to contribute to its midterm review, aimed at assessing the progress achieved by the various parties as well as making recommendations to reach our common objectives.

Belgium would like to reaffirm its commitment to the guiding principles and priorities for action formulated in the Sendai Framework. In that perspective, our country is intensifying its collaboration with various partners around the world in order to develop a wider vision of risks and deepen its expertise in the field of crisis management.

Belgium also strongly supports the establishment of international frameworks enhancing preparedness, response capability and resilience to future crises. We attach great importance to the complementarity of those international frameworks from the United Nations, NATO, the European Union and others.

We in Belgium are currently establishing a single national security strategy covering all the requirements and objectives of those various international frameworks. Besides the classical requirements, three additional areas of focus have been added, namely, financial resilience, the protection of economic and scientific potential, and psychological resilience. Moreover, the Belgian authorities have also adapted their strategic vision of crisis management to make the concept of resilience an integral part of their policy guidelines.

During the many crises and disasters that we have faced in recent years, a clear chain of command was essential in order to manage those crises efficiently. During those difficult times, Belgium, fortunately, was able to rely on well-defined crisis-management structures where all stakeholders were well aware of their role and responsibilities. Nevertheless, after the terrible floods that we faced in the summer of 2021, a commission of experts in crisis management was set up to draw lessons from that experience and to make recommendations to the Government. The Commission recommended further development of the culture of risk and the integration of citizens in that risk cycle. It also looked at best practices to build back better after a crisis.

In that challenging context, the need to adapt the legal framework became evident in order to enable more effective risk management. Currently, new legislation

bringing together all emergency plans, at both the national and local levels, is being drafted.

In addition, Belgium has not underestimated and will not underestimate the growing impact of climate-change risks. We recently set up a centre for complex risk assessments to develop complex and multidisciplinary risk assessments in the context of climate change. As we are still developing the parameters of such assessments, we are keen to engage with and learn from other countries that are working with such risk assessments.

Despite all those improvements, I am very concerned by the increasing frequency and intensity of crises. If we want to accelerate progress towards reducing risk and building resilience in a cross-sectoral context — and thus achieve our common goals — we will need greater investment. That is why Belgium supports the strengthening of the resilience of vulnerable communities around the world, especially in Africa and in the least developed countries.

I would like to highlight our strong support for the Least Developed Countries Fund, which is intended to support least developed countries in their climate-change adaptation efforts. Belgium pledged €75 million in 2021-2024. We have heard the call of the Secretary-General to roll out a global early-warning system, and we are prepared to do our part in that multilateral effort.

Belgium welcomes this midterm review and is looking forward to the policy recommendations and practical solutions that will emerge from our exchanges. There is no time to waste; we need to act, because if not now, when? We must act in a thoughtful and joint manner in order to safeguard and guarantee fair development and the well-being of our global citizens.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Minister for the Interior of Ghana.

Mr. Dery (Ghana): Ghana supports the political declaration (resolution 77/289).

I align myself with the statements to be delivered later by the representatives of Cuba and South Africa, speaking on behalf of the Group of 77 and China and the Group of African States, respectively.

In May 2015, the world endorsed the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030. The commitment was strong, and we waited to see its

impact. In furtherance of that commitment, the African Union came up with a programme of action with additional, African-focused targets.

The Sendai Framework was designed to be coterminous with the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development. It was to enhance the implementation of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Needless to say, the Sustainable Development Goals were pursued within the macro environment of risks and disasters, and the Sendai Framework ensures risk-informed sustainable development.

We are witnesses to the increasing losses across the world caused by disasters — earthquakes, floods, mudslides, heatwaves and conflicts, among others. The frequency of disasters and their increasing intensity have exacerbated the disaster menace. In addition, the systemic nature of risk and its resultant residuality have changed the risk narrative.

Permit me to touch on the coronavirus disease (COVID-19) pandemic, which revealed the hidden vulnerabilities of our countries. Our weaknesses were exposed, and the need for the implementation of the Sendai Framework was emphasized.

COVID-19 taught us bitter lessons in the area of preparedness. Our Government has therefore carried out a number of post-COVID initiatives. One such initiative is the establishment of a national vaccine institute to build local capacity and to develop direction and implementation for vaccine production and manufacturing to meet future pandemics.

The residual socioeconomic effects of the pandemic are affecting all of us tremendously. Financing disaster risk reduction continues to be a challenge. Permit me to mention the fact that the importance of investment in resilient infrastructure, early-warning systems and disaster risk insurance schemes cannot be overemphasized.

We welcome the partnership with the private sector and innovative financing mechanisms such as disaster risk insurance to finance disaster risk reduction measures. Those nonetheless would require a prioritization of needs and the maximization of the use of resources, as well as a recognition of the need for weak economies to attain economic resilience.

I appeal to the relevant stakeholders to make good on their obligation pursuant to the groundbreaking agreement reached at the twenty-seventh session of

the Conference of the Parties to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change to provide loss and damage assistance to vulnerable nations severely affected by floods, droughts and other climate-related disasters. Funding is key.

Ghana has taken steps to implement the Sendai Framework over the years. We have revised our national building code to take into consideration the current hazard profile. Ghana is faced with the threat of earthquakes, with the country experiencing frequent tremors. To solve that problem holistically, the country has developed a comprehensive plan to redirect our focus to deal with earthquake preparedness and response. We have realized that the local government system would be effective for the implementation of the Sendai Framework.

In Ghana, the local government system, called District Assemblies, has decentralized operations. The Government has a system in place to ensure that disaster risk reduction is mainstreamed in their medium-term plans before they are approved for implementation.

Since the local government level is the hub of national development, disaster risk reduction at that level has afforded enhanced sustainability for the Sendai Framework and, ultimately, the SDGs. To address environmental problems, we have embarked on a number of measures and interventions. The greening programme, which consists of planting trees, is owned by the citizenry. Each year the programme is rolled out to ensure a reduction in the greenhouse effect.

The implementation of the Sendai Framework in Ghana faces challenges. Illegal surface mining, termed *galamsey*, has polluted our water bodies and poses a threat to the survival of future generations. The problem is complex and has economic, social and cultural dimensions. The Government is committed to fighting the *galamsey* menace in Ghana.

The world faces increasing risks from climate-change-related disasters. We call on all stakeholders to come together in building more resilient communities and reducing the impact of disasters. We need to consider ways of addressing the linkages between climate change and disaster risk reduction.

We owe future generations the right to life. We must bequeath to them an environment with a balanced ecosystem. We must gird our loins to save our planet.

In his opening remarks, the President made a profound statement, in which he said that profit is prized over people. To support that statement, which I agree with, I wish to quote from *The Deserted Village*, by Oliver Goldsmith:

“Ill fares the land, to hastening ill a prey,
Where wealth accumulates and men decay”.

Let us not go down that road.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Minister of Interior of Luxembourg.

Ms. Bofferding (Luxembourg) (*spoke in French*): I wish to take advantage of this opportunity to thank the President of the General Assembly and the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Disaster Risk Reduction for having convened this midterm review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030. Indeed, this meeting offers us an opportunity to assess the activities undertaken and, above all, to discuss the efforts currently under way as well as those that are planned in the area of disaster risk reduction to ensure coordination in our efforts to strengthen them to yield a resilience that goes beyond our own borders.

Luxembourg aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of the European Union.

The complex crises and disasters facing us in recent years reflect the urgency, importance and relevance of the goals and priorities set out in the Sendai Framework. We have seen that risks are increasingly systemic and interconnected. To respond to those risks, we need to adapt our governance mechanisms with an eye to improving our understanding of risks, bolstering prevention and preparation, and, above all, accelerating change in order to move from a reactive approach to disaster management towards one that is more anticipatory and proactive.

Concrete action is therefore needed at all levels, above all to strengthen the resilience of our societies. Therefore, Luxembourg moved in 2020 to establish a national platform for disaster risk reduction tasked with the implementation of the Sendai Framework. Since then, major progress has been achieved. For example, we have integrated organizations of persons with disabilities into the platform.

It is important to take account, in the process of risk assessment, of the various vulnerabilities that exist in

our society and to give that issue due attention in order to determine the appropriate actions that must be taken.

I am also pleased at the cooperation under way with community sector representatives, who have contributed, as members of our national platform, to the bolstering of national resilience by strengthening it at the local level.

The efforts of representatives of various sectors have helped us better understand risks in order to ultimately raise the awareness of all stakeholders and to achieve, or even strengthen, resilience at all levels. Additional efforts are needed in order to craft a society that is resilient to risk, and I believe that that goal cannot be achieved except by providing clear, accessible information.

I assure the Assembly that Luxembourg will endeavour to strengthen its activities aimed at raising awareness about the risks facing the population. That is why my Government is currently working to establish an information and warning system for the people that is even more accessible. Well-informed citizens will be resilient, prepared and less vulnerable to disasters.

Luxembourg will therefore continue its activities. In 2022, we supported risk-reduction activities to the tune of roughly €1.5 million. Luxembourg will maintain its support for the United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction and will continue to support our various humanitarian partners in their efforts to reduce risks and prepare for natural disasters.

Together, we can achieve a world that is more resilient — a world that is able to address the challenges that we will face going forward.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Minister of Home Affairs of Barbados.

Mr. Abrahams (Barbados): Two decades ago, the Barbados Government adopted as a national policy the tenets of the Caribbean Strategy on Comprehensive Disaster Management. The Strategy, which is coordinated and supported by the Caribbean Disaster Emergency Management Agency (CDEMA), regionally emphasizes a whole-of-society partnership and collaboration in tackling and reducing the risks and losses associated with the multiple hazards that may impact the lives and livelihoods of the Barbadian people and the country's landscape.

The CDEMA is recognized and endorsed at the highest political level as the vehicle by which Barbados and the wider Caribbean implement the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030.

The management and reduction of risk are inextricably linked to national resilience and sustainable development. It is therefore within such a context that building resilience to the multiple hazards that may affect us remains a national priority. My Government's thrust nationally has included a focus on strengthening the governance mechanisms for comprehensive disaster management. Thus we recently approved a rearticulated national comprehensive disaster management policy and developed a multi-hazard early-warning system and a policy and road map for news programmes, among others.

Likewise, we continue to raise awareness and promote disaster risk advocacy at all levels and build resilience at the community and grass-roots levels, as we have acknowledged that communities are on the front line of that resilience undertaking.

We continue to strengthen our national and response mechanism, ensuring that our operational readiness and posture is adequate, scalable and possesses the flexibility to manage any emergency or disaster. We agitate for and mobilize predictable financing to support disaster risk management efforts, and we encourage and provide a pathway for the mainstreaming and investment of disaster risk management solutions into the various sectors, such as those within the blue and green economies.

Cognizant of the importance of and the need to accelerate disaster risk reduction and resilience initiatives and to show solidarity regionally and globally, Barbados recently hosted and endorsed at the highest political level the United Nations global initiative on an emergency warning system for all. We express our gratitude to the Secretary-General for having been included as one of the countries selected in the initial phase of that global public-good initiative. We view that initiative as an investment in the preservation of humankind, as early warning will save lives.

In every system, accountability is a critical component. Periodic assessment, monitoring, evaluation and reporting are essential as we take stock of challenges and progress in the Sendai Framework implementation process. Barbados is therefore pleased to contribute our official national voluntary report

for the midterm review of the Sendai Framework implementation. We are in solidarity with the Americas and, as such, have contributed to the regional position of the Americas.

We also take this opportunity to graciously express our gratitude to the Eastern Republic of Uruguay for its initiative. Additionally, we compliment the United Nations and all countries present here for actively participating in this critical midterm review process. This midterm review must acknowledge the impact of the coronavirus disease on the pace of implementation thus far. We also must accept that we are behind the eight ball. We must recommend measures for acceleration and provide additional support for small States that have limited resources and capacity.

We urge Governments, the private sector, international donors and financial institutions to consider the Bridgetown initiative as a practical and innovative approach to supporting the sustainability and viability of small island developing States (SIDS). The creation of a balanced or level playing field must be a global goal if SIDS are to have a fighting chance.

Barbados will continue to utilize its voice as a proponent of and advocate for resilience and for climate justice and climate action that fully addresses our critical concerns as SIDS; for the collective leveraging and mobilization of adequate national, regional and international resources to support disaster risk resilience programming; and for the simplification, I repeat, for the simplification of access to predictable development financing by small island developing States to aid in tackling disaster risk and losses as well as climate change.

It is imperative that words now be translated into action: deliberate, swift, science-informed, evidence-based targeted action — action that is timely, pragmatic and builds on past knowledge and experiences. Such action must be underpinned by bold, decisive and transformational leadership, and it must realize and demonstrate an earnest investment in humankind at all levels. We must be people-centred in our approach and our solutions

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Minister for Climate Crisis and Civil Protection of Greece.

Mr. Stylianides (Greece): First, let me thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General

for Disaster Risk Reduction, Mami Mizutori, for her initiative of organizing this midterm review on the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030.

Before I continue, allow me to express my deep condolences to my Italian colleagues in connection with the tragic loss of life during the severe floods of the last few days. Our thoughts are with the families of the victims and all those who are affected by the disaster.

As one who had the honour and the pleasure to be part of the negotiations that led to the original Sendai Framework, as a former European Commissioner, I am particularly pleased to join this gathering here today. The Sendai Framework was a bold and ambitious text that followed the Hyogo Framework for Action. It has been the global blueprint for the disaster risk reduction effort. It is a call for action and concrete measures.

Eight years later, this midterm review is a milestone. It is an opportunity to take stock of the progress made so far, to identify gaps, to revisit national strategies and to reflect on the next steps, of course, taking into account the hard reality of climate change and the climate crisis.

In our country, in Greece, Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis took an innovative decision to establish a ministry for climate crisis and civil protection, bringing the causal relationship between the climate crisis and natural disasters to the forefront. Within that framework, we are putting scientific knowledge and expertise at the core of our decision-making policies and processes. We are therefore establishing a national database for all natural and man-made disasters, which will be supported by various teams of scientists and experts, monitoring and modelling all relevant data to inform in advance the operational arm of our response mechanism.

That instrument will be the scientific arm of the upgraded Greek national crisis coordination centre and, of course, our operational arm, the Hellenic Fire Brigade. In addition, greater synergy and better collaboration as well as the exchange of good practices among countries are key, not only in Europe but globally in Asia, in Africa and in Latin America.

To that end, we are working closely with our European partners. More specifically, we are actively engaged with the European Union Civil Protection Mechanism and rescEU, the most important and

successful instrument for cooperation in the field of disaster management in Europe.

Greece has already become the rescEU hub for the eastern Mediterranean, and we have taken the initiative to establish robust regional cooperation under the umbrella of the European Union Civil Protection Mechanism.

Looking forward to 2030, we need to strengthen our collective action capabilities and to invest more in education and training to cultivate a culture of prevention and preparedness among our citizens. Last October, the European Forum for Disaster Risk Reduction Roadmap Action-Oriented Dialogue took place in Athens. One of the most important conclusions thereof was that there is a need for a shift in the focus of disaster risk strategies from response to prevention. That must become our common priority, bringing the traditional approach to disaster risk management, which focuses on response with three key pillars, the very well-known triangle: prevention, preparedness and resilience. I strongly believe that this must become our new commitment

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Minister of Defence of Maldives.

Ms. Didi (Maldives): On behalf of His Excellency President Ibrahim Mohamed Solih, I thank President Kőrösi for having convened this high-level meeting of the General Assembly to review and discuss the implementation of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030. This is a matter of great concern for the Maldives, given that small island States such as the Maldives are among the most vulnerable to the impacts of climate change and natural disasters.

Climate change and its associated impacts are already visible in the country. The increasing frequency and intensity of extreme weather events is causing immense damage to livelihoods. Monsoon rains started in early May and are imposing excessive hardships on our communities even as I speak. That has already caused huge losses to our homes and agriculture. Immediately before that, in April, temperatures soared, resulting in bush fires in the south and water shortages across the Maldives, and the cycle keeps repeating.

The degradation of our marine ecosystems due to ocean acidification is impacting our economy and our people's way of life. There is also a vast disparity between the effect of disasters on various communities,

with the vulnerability of populations in the atolls much higher than those in urban centres.

While those challenges pose an existential threat to the Maldives, the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development is an effective avenue for us to work towards resilience at all levels. The Sendai Framework provides a holistic approach to reducing disaster risks and building resilience, and it recognizes the unique challenges facing countries like the Maldives.

The implementation of the framework will be a huge leap in the right direction in protecting our communities and ecosystems, and is essential to secure a sustainable and prosperous future for our peoples.

It would be a missed opportunity if we did not capitalize on the progress made so far. The midterm review has identified areas of regression and stagnation, highlighting the need to accelerate our efforts to achieve the goals of the Framework.

The causal relationship between climate change and the rise in disaster risk emphasizes the need for a systematic and integrated approach to solutions. As aptly noted in the review, innovative solutions are required. Collaboration among policymakers, scientists, engineers and practitioners is required to achieve that. The integration and harmonization of policies and strategies at the national and local levels is also needed.

We in the Maldives have incorporated disaster risk reduction into a national strategic action plan. With that we are accelerating the adoption of disaster risk reduction programmes across sectors. That has also enabled key stakeholders to prioritize their efforts and work towards disaster risk reduction in a more coordinated manner. We are also examining how we can best incorporate disaster risk reduction into adaptation plans.

For resource-constrained small island nations such as the Maldives, response as a key component of resilience must go hand in hand with the risk reduction discussion. The magnitude of the challenges facing us is enormous; only through collective effort can we hope to overcome them. In working together to achieve the goals of the Sendai Framework, let us commit to a more sustainable and prosperous future for all.

This morning we heard Mustafa's touching story. We must come together as leaders and lead by example. We need action now. I assure the Assembly that

Maldives is 100 per cent committed to the achievement of our common goals.

The Acting President: I now give the floor to the Minister for the Environment of Angola.

Ms. De Carvalho Pereira (Angola) (*spoke in Portuguese; English text provided by the delegation*): I congratulate the President of the General Assembly for having organized this important meeting, at which we are addressing the midterm review of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030. It is an honour for my delegation to be able to share what the Republic of Angola has done towards its implementation.

The systemic nature of risk and the shocks that cascade through sectors and geographical areas require a reassessment of approaches in order to understand, manage and reduce risks, whether they be caused by human, natural, environmental, climate, biological, technological or other factors.

Though progress has been made in the implementation of the Sendai Framework since its adoption, in 2015, it still is not enough, and failure to apply the Sendai Framework undermines the achievement of the objectives and goals of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and other intergovernmental agreements and conventions, including the Paris Agreement and the Kunming-Montreal Global Biodiversity Framework. Our understanding of economic, social, political and ecological risk factors is improving, but further and significant changes in governance are still required.

Angola is one of the sub-Saharan African countries that has suffered most from the impact of climate change and extreme climate events, with floods and drought being the most significant natural events in our country. The scale and impact of disasters on lives, livelihoods and ecosystems are on the rise and have hampered the entire development process undertaken by the executive branch of the Angolan Government, and economic losses due to disasters undermine the efforts made to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals, as those costs deprive the Government of funds that could be used for health care, education, social protection and other important public needs.

Angola ratified the Sendai Framework in 2015; it became a priority for the Government, which approved the national development plan, which included a disaster risk reduction component in all sectors and actions to

consolidate the prevention, mitigation, response and recovery strategy for any disaster situations that may occur, using the civil protection law.

The Angolan national commission on civil protection, through various ministerial departments, has been implementing strategic disaster risk prevention and reduction as well as the national preparedness, contingency, response and recovery plan against disasters and calamities, which is undergoing review. The provincial plans for development cover eight of our country's 18 provinces, or 45 per cent of our national territory.

In the context of the African Union's plan of action on disaster risk reduction in Africa, the implementation of a disaster prevention project in schools and communities is under way. That project, in partnership with UNICEF, has developed teaching materials that address subjects related to droughts, floods, malaria, natural calamities and other cross-cutting themes that will be integrated into the educational system's curriculum in Angola.

The executive branch of Angola's Government has endeavoured to create and implement projects for early-warning systems to ensure that communities are informed of any threats to which they are subject, as well as response mechanisms to safeguard human lives and people's livelihoods.

In the southern region of our country, specifically in the province of Benguela, the early-warning-system stations in Caiave, along the Catumbela River, and along the Coporolo River are operational. The data gathered at those stations allows us to remotely monitor measurements such as water levels in the rivers so that the appropriate entities may make decisions promptly. It is important to note that major investments have been made to upgrade national weather services in order to better support key economic sectors and more efficiently monitor the weather.

Angola is proud of having been chosen as focal point for the implementation of the Southern African Development Community's weather-service programme — the Climate Services and Related Application programme — whose sole purpose is to strengthen the value chain of weather services in order to incentivize the use of weather monitoring and forecasting products in climate risk management and environmental management.

Angola has adopted a national climate-change strategy and plans to implement the monitoring, verification and reporting mechanism and to install a national weather observatory. We intend to create a local response capacity with the establishment of disaster risk management committees in order to develop wider participation by the population and civil society in general, thus allowing citizens to identify and understand their vulnerabilities and the threats and level of risk to which they are exposed.

In conclusion, we reiterate our national commitment to achieving the seven global targets as well as the five

African targets under the Sendai Framework. We must carry out increasingly coordinated actions, particularly with respect to environmental issues and climate change, to incorporate the One Health approach into the human, animal and environmental components as well as the urban and rural resilience approach, and to strengthen governance by developing a national risk management policy.

The Acting President: We have heard the last speaker for this meeting. We shall hear the remaining speakers today in this Hall at 3 p.m.

The meeting rose at 1.05 p.m.